

A TIMES INVESTIGATION

Palisades fire report watered down, files show

Revisions are likely to deepen concerns over the LAFD’s ability to acknowledge mistakes.

By ALENE TCHEKMEDYIAN AND PAUL PRINGLE

For months after the Palisades fire, many who had lost their homes eagerly awaited the Los Angeles Fire Department’s after-action report, which was expected to provide a frank evaluation of the agency’s handling of the disaster.

A first draft was completed by August, possibly earlier.

And then the deletions and other changes began — behind closed doors — in what amounted to an effort to downplay the failures of city and LAFD leadership in preparing for and fighting the Jan. 7 fire, which killed 12 people and destroyed thousands of homes, records obtained by The Times show.

In one instance, LAFD officials removed language saying that the decision not to fully staff up and pre-deploy all available crews and engines ahead of the extreme wind forecast “did not align” with the department’s policy and procedures during red flag days.

Instead, the final report said that the number of engine companies rolled out ahead of the fire “went above and beyond the standard LAFD pre-deployment matrix.”

Another deleted passage in the report said that some crews waited more than an hour for an assignment the day of the fire. A section on “failures” was renamed “primary challenges,” and an item saying that crews and leaders had violated national guidelines on how to avoid firefighter deaths and injuries was scratched.

Other changes in the report, which was overseen by then-interim Fire Chief Ron- [See Palisades, A10]



MYUNG J. CHUN Los Angeles Times



FLORESCIA TAN JUN Sportstyle

TILLY NORWOOD, shown at top in an illustration, is not a real actor but an AI creation of Particle6, a video firm run by CEO Eline van der Velden, above.

Hollywood in turmoil as AI enters the scene

Digital actors force industrywide reckoning

By Josh Rottenberg

Kevin Hart is almost impossible to avoid.

The stand-up comic turned actor has spent the past decade as one of Hollywood’s most bankable and visible stars, headlining megahits like the “Jumanji” films alongside a steady output of comedies and animated features, while still selling out arena tours and releasing hit Netflix comedy specials. Off-screen, his face turns up everywhere: pitching banking apps, tequila and energy drinks.

For a long time, that kind of omnipresence carried real security in Hollywood. In the era of artificial intelligence, though, that guarantee has begun to erode. A quick Google search for “Kevin Hart AI” turns up unofficial versions of his voice, available with a few clicks.

That helps explain why, one evening last month on the Fox lot, the head of Hart’s entertainment company, Hartbeat, was on an industry panel talking not about box of-

fice or release strategies but AI. Jeff Clanan painted a picture of a landscape in which movie stardom is no longer protected by traditional channels, as attention splinters across platforms and audiences fragment. In that environment, AI can be both a risk and a lever.

“The most valuable resource right now is attention,” Clanan told the audience of 150 studio executives, filmmakers, investors and technologists gathered at Hollywood X, an invitation-only event focused on responsible adoption of AI. “You’re competing for it everywhere — everybody is always on a second screen. That fragmentation is where the disruption is.”

Hollywood was built on the idea that a small number of stars could reliably command attention and turn it into leverage. As AI and algorithm-driven platforms reshape how attention is created and distributed, even the most recognizable names [See Hollywood, A14]

A TIMES INVESTIGATION

The untold cost of claims over past sex abuse

State law opened lawsuit window, and schools are paying the price

By MATT HAMILTON

Starting in 2020, survivors of childhood sex abuse in California were given a powerful tool to confront their abusers and the institutions that employed them.

Churches. Schools. Youth sports leagues. Boy Scouts. Foster care homes. Juvenile justice wards. Summer camps. Boarding schools. All were suddenly on notice that survivors had a three-year window to pursue a lawsuit over past molestation and sexual assault.

For survivors, the law — Assembly Bill 218 — afforded them their day in court, empowering generations to gain reparations for what had long haunted them and confront perpetrators and the institutions that covered up abuse.

Though the law has provided a measure of healing, it has unleashed an unprecedented wave of litigation on many of the nearly 1,000 public school districts in Califor-

nia. Scores of former students have come forth with allegations of rape and molestation dating to the 1950s. This reckoning has upended school budgets, drained district coffers, triggered cuts to programs, threatened cost-of-living increases for teachers and even contributed to layoffs, a Times investigation found.

It has also raised questions of whether a noble effort to address the deep wounds of childhood sexual abuse has imposed a collateral penalty on today’s students, with little public awareness of the true financial cost.

The Times sought records from 937 school districts in the state to assess the impact of the three-year lifting of the statute of limitations under AB 218. The law also greatly expanded the universe of people who could sue going forward, by extending the age at which a [See Abuse, A8]



AMANDA EDWARDS Getty Images for the Women's March Los Angeles

FILMMAKER Rob Reiner speaks at the Women’s March Los Angeles rally downtown on Jan. 20, 2018.

Reaching across the political divide

A fierce liberal activist, Reiner still managed to build ties with conservatives.

By HAILEY BRANSON-POTTS, SEEMA MEHTA AND MARK OLSEN

In January 2018, conservative Fox News host Laura Ingraham was having dinner at Toscana, an Italian restaurant in Brentwood, when she spotted the renowned Hollywood director — and unabashed liberal — Rob Reiner.

She asked him to come

on her show, “The Ingraham Angle.” He was on set the next day.

After introducing him as “a brilliant director,” who made her favorite movie, “This Is Spinal Tap,” Ingraham said: “Last night, the first thing Reiner says is: ‘Are they gonna shut the government down?’ I’m like, wow, I’m here in L.A.; I wanna talk about Hollywood stuff. But he wants to talk about politics.”

Ingraham and Reiner vehemently disagreed — about alleged Russian influence on the 2016 presidential election, about whether President Trump is racist, about the treatment of conserva- [See Reiner, A12]

Gaps in Epstein files stir impeachment threat

By KEVIN RECTOR AND MICHAEL WILNER

WASHINGTON — Lawmakers unhappy with Justice Department decisions to heavily redact or withhold documents from a legally mandated release of files related to Jeffrey Epstein threatened Saturday to launch impeachment proceedings against those responsible, including Pam Bondi, the U.S. attorney general.

Democrats and Republicans alike criticized the omissions, while Democrats also accused the Justice Department of intentionally scrubbing the release of at least one image of President Trump, with Senate Minority Leader Chuck Schumer (D-N.Y.) suggesting it could portend “one of the biggest

coverups in American history.”

Trump administration officials have said the release fully complied with the law, and that its redactions were crafted only to protect victims of Epstein, a disgraced financier and convicted sex offender accused of abusing hundreds of women and girls before his death in 2019.

Rep. Ro Khanna (D-Fre-

mont), an author of the Epstein Files Transparency Act, which required the release of the investigative trove, blasted Bondi in a social media video, accusing her of denying the existence of many of the records for months, only to push out “an incomplete release with too many redactions” in response to — and in violation of — the new law. [See Epstein, A10]

Airbnb prices soar with demand as World Cup games in L.A. approach

By JACK FLEMMING AND HAILEY WANG

On June 12, Peggy Orenstein’s inbox flooded with booking requests for her Inglewood Airbnb.

The date seemed random, but after a quick search, the reason for the influx of interest became clear. It was exactly one year before one of the biggest events in American soccer history, when the U.S. will kick off its World Cup in a match against Paraguay at SoFi Stadium, and Orenstein had set up the system to only

accept booking requests up to a year in advance.

Orenstein’s rental sits just across the street from the venue. Suddenly, her Airbnb became one of the hottest homes in the Southland.

She hadn’t adjusted the prices yet to reflect the rabid demand, so she declined the requests and tweaked the rates. Typically, a two-night stay at the house would cost around \$1,000. For a two-night stay during the Americans’ opening match June 12, it’ll now cost more than \$10,000.

Roughly 6.5 million peo-

ple are expected to travel to North America during the 2026 World Cup, and many of them will be heading to L.A., where SoFi Stadium is hosting eight games, including two U.S. matches during the group stage. Airbnb hosts are viewing the games as a gold mine, hoping soccer fans will shell out thousands to stay near the stadium.

The World Cup rental market will serve as a test case for the 2028 Olympics, when an estimated 15 million people are expected to visit Southern California.

For the night of the open- [See Airbnb, A6]



CHRISTINA HOUSE Los Angeles Times

AFTER THE FIRES

Nearly a year after the Eaton and Palisades fires, we take a critical look at what went wrong, the struggles in rebuilding and the future. **SECTION U**

U.S. intercepts another tanker

The military stops a second vessel this month amid Trump’s pressure campaign on Venezuela. **WORLD, A3**

They’ve got a foggy notion

Central Valley haze stirs online theories, but it probably carries air pollutants, scientists say. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Weather Clouds clearing. L.A. Basin: 70/49. **B8**

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